

NREGA has MADE A HUGE DIFFERENCE TO THE RURAL ECONOMY, IMPROVING ROADS, WATER, POWER AND EDUCATION, PROMPTING grassroots leaders TO THINK OUT OF THE BOX.



KUDUMBASREE
WOMEN'S PROJECT
KERALA

Mararikulam North, a village in Alappuzha, has seen a revolution thanks to Kudumbasree, which has empowered lakhs of women by making them financially independent through entrepreneurship. Despite their school-level education, its members get bank loans to set up units.

has seen improved connectivity. Rs 5,400 crore has been spent in the last five years and the better connectivity has led to speedier transportation of goods and services. Improved power supply has helped women like Laxmi Devi, sarpanch of Bachamad village, to have a washing machine at home: it saves time and lets her do more productive work. Other small village entrepreneurs from tailors and carpenters to plumbers can work longer hours and more efficiently with power tools. Regular power also means that drinking water supply comes at a fixed time and village women no longer waste hours waiting to collect water from community taps.

Elsewhere, as in Theni, the 100 days of NREGA has given local youth greater disposable income and boosted the earnings of retail dealers in items like mobile phones and garments. "Sales have boomed. It has become essential for everyone to have a mobile phone," says Selvaraj, a local dealer. Private hospitals, banks, mini-malls, dealers in a variety of goods and services are visible all across rural India, and some shops even sell bottled water!

To really judge the fast changing socio-economic face of rural India, the state of its

tribal population is crucial.

They represent the final frontier, being exploited for decades because of ignorance, poverty and lack of opportunity. So, it is a surprise when one speaks to Kantilal Baria, 25, from Dhekalgaon village of Jhabua district deep in western Madhya Pradesh. He belongs to a generation of Bhil tribals that has seen its community undergo historical change. As a child, Baria's world was frozen in time—bare-chested, barefoot, loin-clothed tribals carrying bows and arrows to hunt for food. Today, all that has changed because of NREGA, which provides 100 days of minimum wages a year, raising income levels and aspirations. An estimated 1-1.25 lakh tribals from Jhabua work at construction sites in Gujarat, Rajasthan or Mumbai and Goa where wages are higher. The girls wear saris and young men are clad in cheap denims and imitation Ray Ban shades but they all own cellphones. Some even have motorcycles. The tribal dude has arrived.

So has the rural one. Nothing perhaps illustrates the remarkable changes in rural India than Kalahandi, once described as India's heart of darkness. Today, women wear decent saris, gold rings and other ornaments and have been given jobs at the local centre for female healthcare and education. Those desperate days of starvation and near-death are a distant memory. Just like everything else once associated with rural India. A latest Assocham study says that rural per capita income is expected to increase from Rs 7,335 in 1981 to Rs 15,396, at a compounded annual growth rate of 2.5 per cent. It also projected an increase in rural income from Rs 8,00,000 crore in 2001 to Rs 13,00,000 crore in 2011. It's been a remarkable transformation and if rural India stays on its present course, Bharat will be the pulse, or pulses, of the future.

with inputs from Ambreesh Mishra, Malini Bhupta, Shyamal Yadav, Arvind Chhabra, Abhijit Dasgupta, Mahalingam Ponnuswamy, A. Rammohanrao, Stephen David, Subhash Mishra, Uday Mahurkar, Rohit Parihar and Farzand Ahmed

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